9V9 FORMATION GUIDE

3-1-3-1

A starting shape, four rules and a job for every position.

INSIDE

01 Starting shape

02 Four playing principles

03 A job for every player

04 Coaching reminders



THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING POSITION. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.

WELCOME

A complete guide to one way of playing 9v9: where nine players start, four principles everyone can remember, a job for every position, and how the team attacks and defends together.

WHO IT'S FOR

Volunteer coaches running a 9v9 team, including parents who are new to coaching. You don't need a coaching qualification to use it.

Share it with assistant coaches and parents, so everyone uses the same words.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1. Start with the starting shape and the four principles.
2. Use the position pages to explain each job to your players.
3. Take the coaching reminders on page 22 to training and matches.
4. Scan the QR code on the back cover for the animated online guide.

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Symbols, and who wears which number.

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Where the nine players begin, and the spine that runs through the middle.

02 OUR FOUR PLAYING PRINCIPLES — 6
Four short rules, each with its own illustrated lesson.

03 A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER — 14
What each position does, and one question every player can ask themselves.

04 COACHING REMINDERS — 22
Every cue from this guide on one page.

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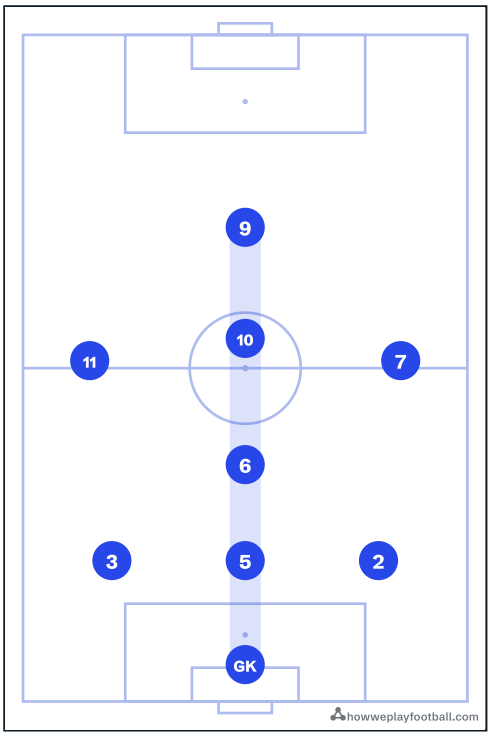
READING THE DIAGRAMS

We always attack up the page. Online, these pictures move. In print, each one shows a single moment.

THE SYMBOLS

US	Our players, numbered by position.
THEM	The other team.
BALL	Where the ball is.
STARTED HERE	Where a player was before they moved.
RUN	A player moving.
PASS	The ball moving.
BLOCKED	A pass that is blocked, or a place not to be.
KEY SPACE	The space that matters in this moment.
GAP	A space we have left open.
✓ RIGHT ✕ WRONG	What we want to see, and what we want to avoid.
A · B · C 1 · 2	Letters mark separate pictures. Numbers mark steps: read them in order.

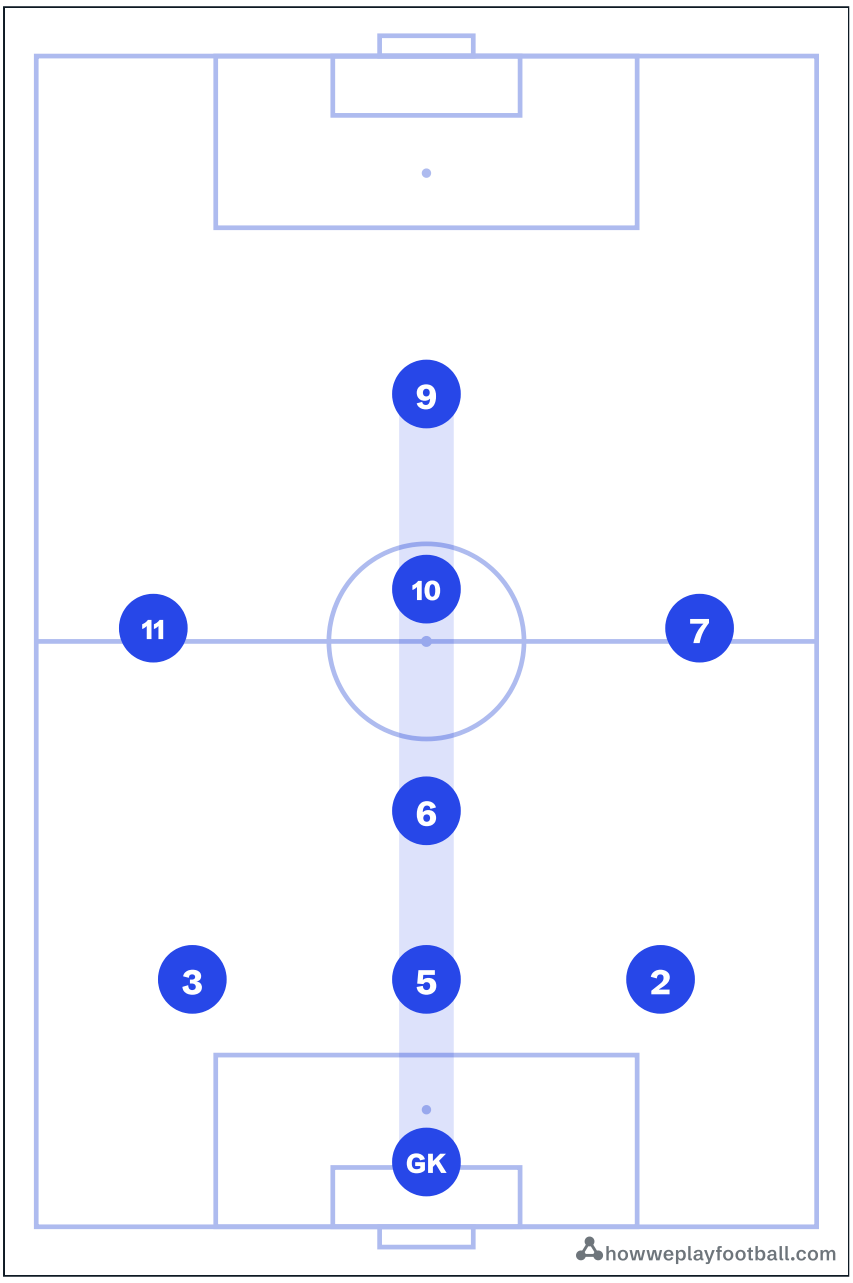
WHO'S WHO



GK	Goalkeeper
5	Centre-back
2 · 3	Outside defenders
6	The screen
7 · 11	Wide players
10	Number 10
9	Striker

01 STARTING SHAPE

Where the nine players begin, and the spine that runs through the middle.



Starting shape: 1-3-1-3-1. We attack up the page.

THE SHAPE

NOTATION
1-3-1-3-1 (goalkeeper first) · 3-1-3-1 (outfield)

BACK LINE
3

MIDFIELD
1 screen, then 3 across

FORWARDS
1

OUR SPINE

Runs through the middle: **GK, 5, 6, 10, 9**. It is shaded on the diagram.

THIS SHAPE GIVES US

1 THREE DEFENDERS

2 PROTECTION THROUGH THE MIDDLE

3 WIDTH ON BOTH SIDES

4 A 10 CLOSE TO THE STRIKER

5 FOUR PLAYERS WHO CAN QUICKLY JOIN AN ATTACK

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING POSITION. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.

THE FOUR PRINCIPLES AT A GLANCE

01	MIDDLE FIRST	Protect the middle before chasing the ball outside.	6
02	ONE GOES, ONE STAYS	One outside defender can attack. The other stays.	8
03	FAR SIDE IN	When we attack down one side, the opposite wide player attacks the goal.	10
04	SHOW THEM WIDE, THEN GO	Protect the middle, guide them to the touchline, then press together.	12

01 MIDDLE FIRST

Make it difficult for teams to play through us.

Protect the middle before chasing the ball outside.

We defend from inside to outside.

WHO IT INVOLVES

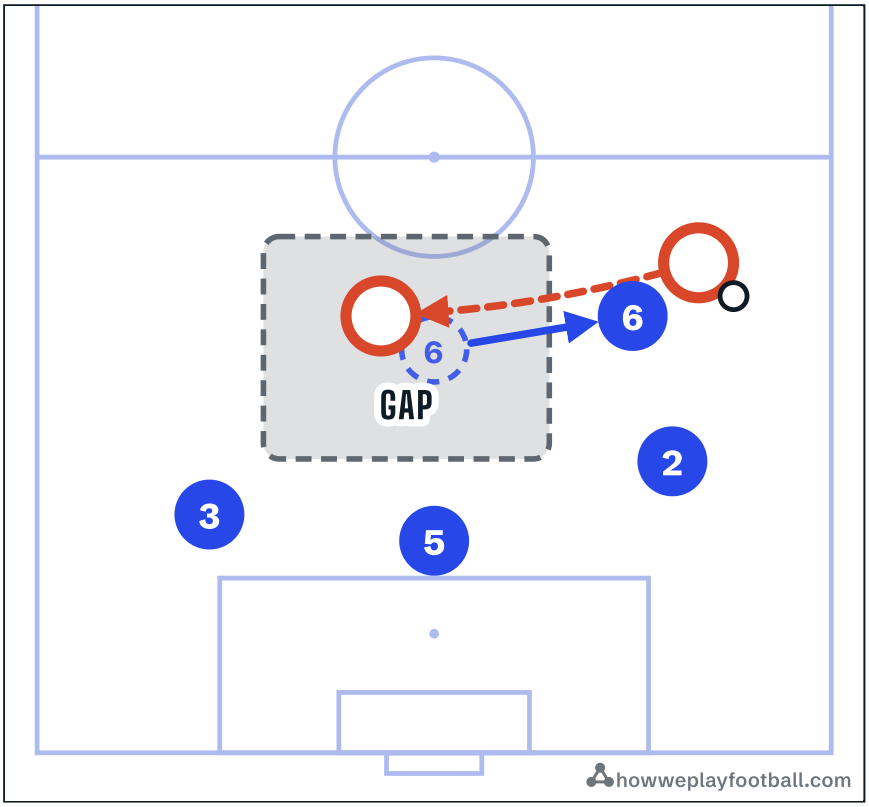
GK Goalkeeper p. 14

5 Centre-back p. 15

6 The screen p. 17

A WRONG

✕ WRONG



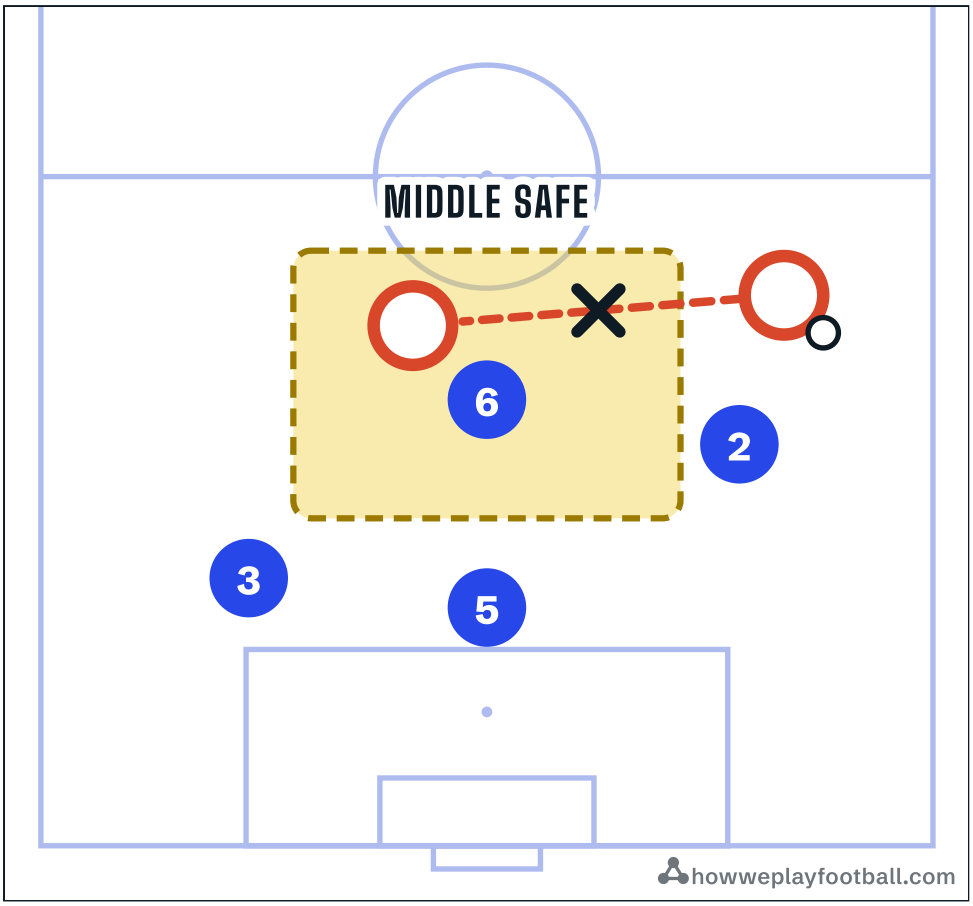
6 is dragged to the touchline. A big gap opens in front of 5.

THE CUE

IF YOU'RE NOT SURE WHETHER TO GO, STAY CENTRAL.

B RIGHT

✓ RIGHT



6 stays central, between the ball and our goal. The middle is closed.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A The 6 stays central, between the ball and our goal.

B Nobody leaves a gap in front of the centre-back (5) to chase the ball wide.

READING THE DIAGRAMS

Us · Them · Ball · Started here · Run · Pass · Blocked · Key space · Gap

02 ONE GOES, ONE STAYS

We can attack without leaving ourselves wide open.

One outside defender can attack. The other stays.

Staying means moving inside a little, next to 5.

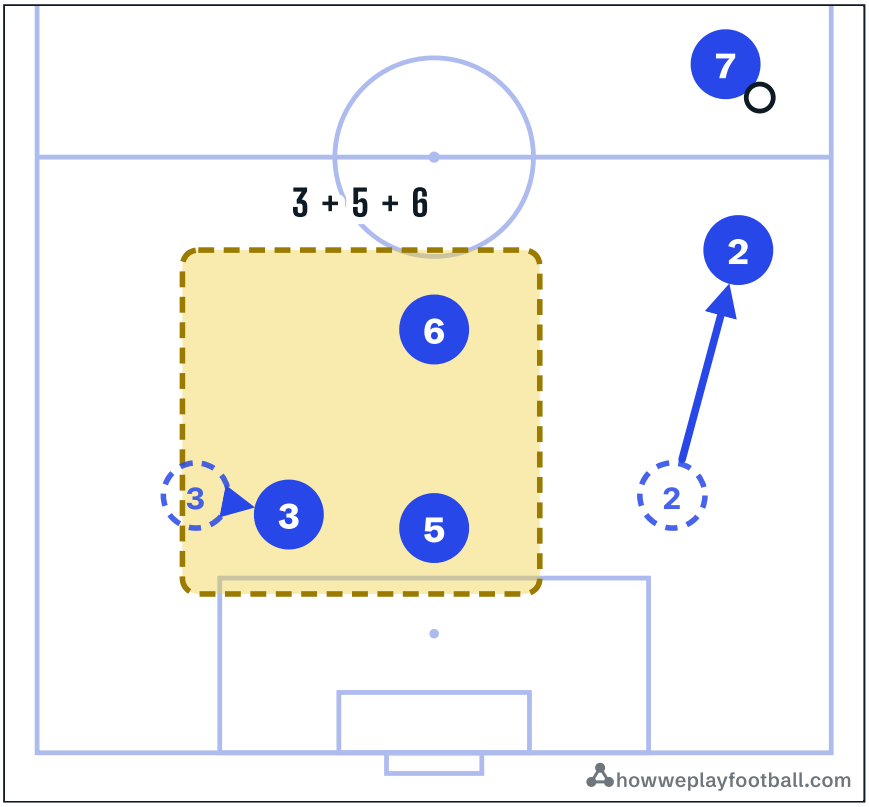
WHO IT INVOLVES

5 Centre-back p. 15

2 · 3 Outside defenders p. 16

A BALL RIGHT

✓ RIGHT



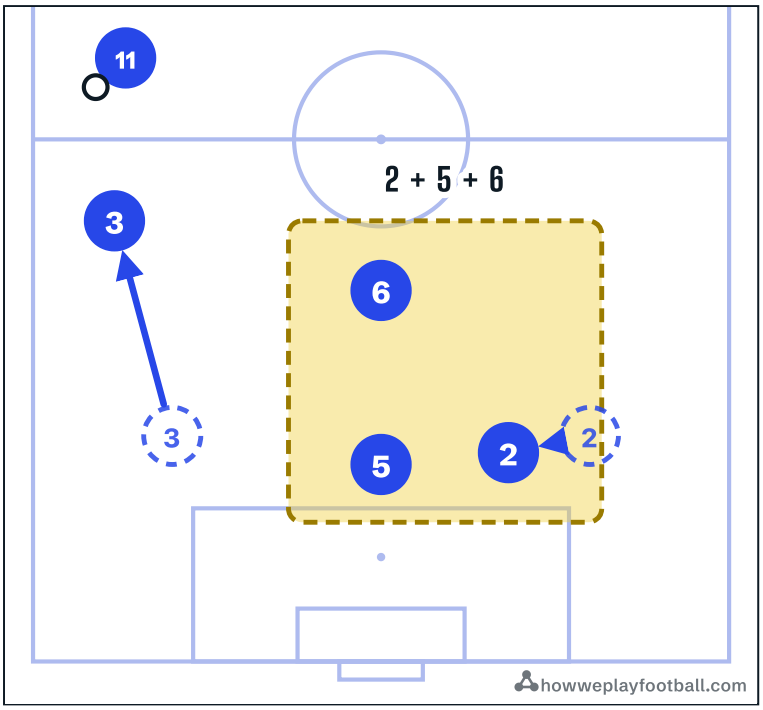
2 goes. 3, 5 and 6 protect us.

THE CUE

IF THE OTHER DEFENDER GOES, YOU STAY.

B BALL LEFT

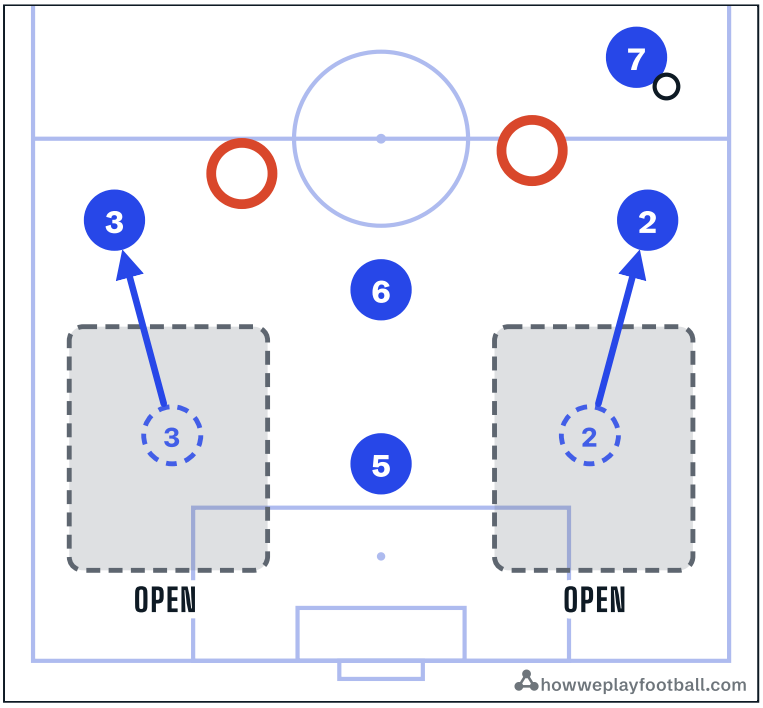
✓ RIGHT



3 goes. 2, 5 and 6 protect us.

C NEVER BOTH

✕ WRONG



Both go forward: both sides are open.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A Ball on the right: 2 goes; 3, 5 and 6 protect us.

B Ball on the left: 3 goes; 2, 5 and 6 protect us.

C Never both: if both go forward, both sides are open.

READING THE DIAGRAMS

Us · Them · Ball · Started here · Run · Pass · Blocked · Key space · Gap

03 FAR SIDE IN

Don't watch the attack. Join it.

When we attack down one side, the opposite wide player attacks the goal.

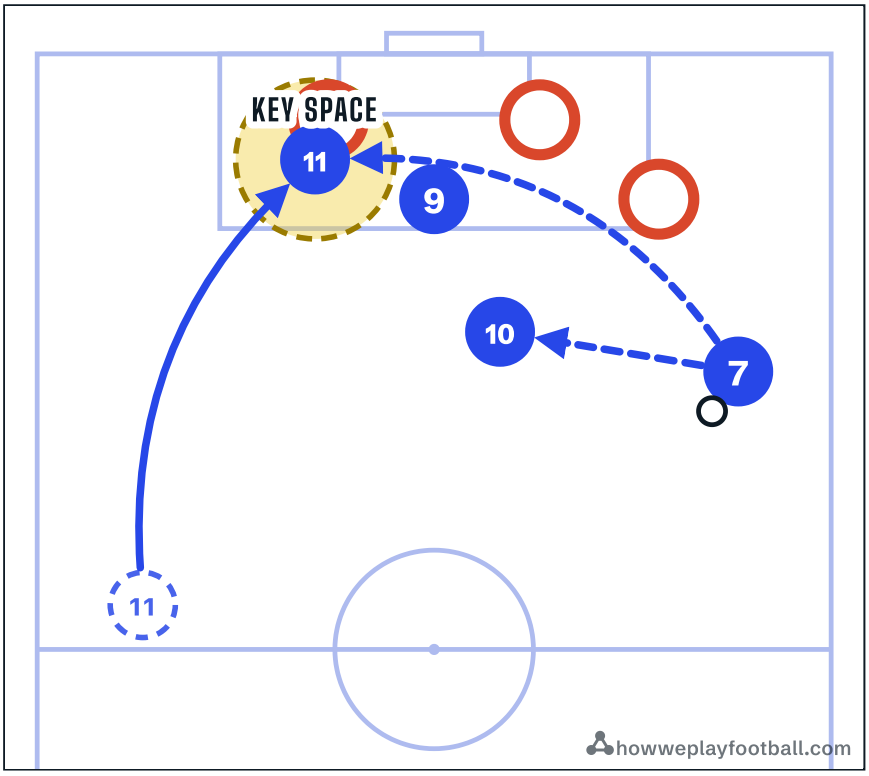
Not one striker: three players who can score.

WHO IT INVOLVES

7 · 11 Wide players p. 18

9 Striker p. 20

A ATTACK DOWN THE RIGHT

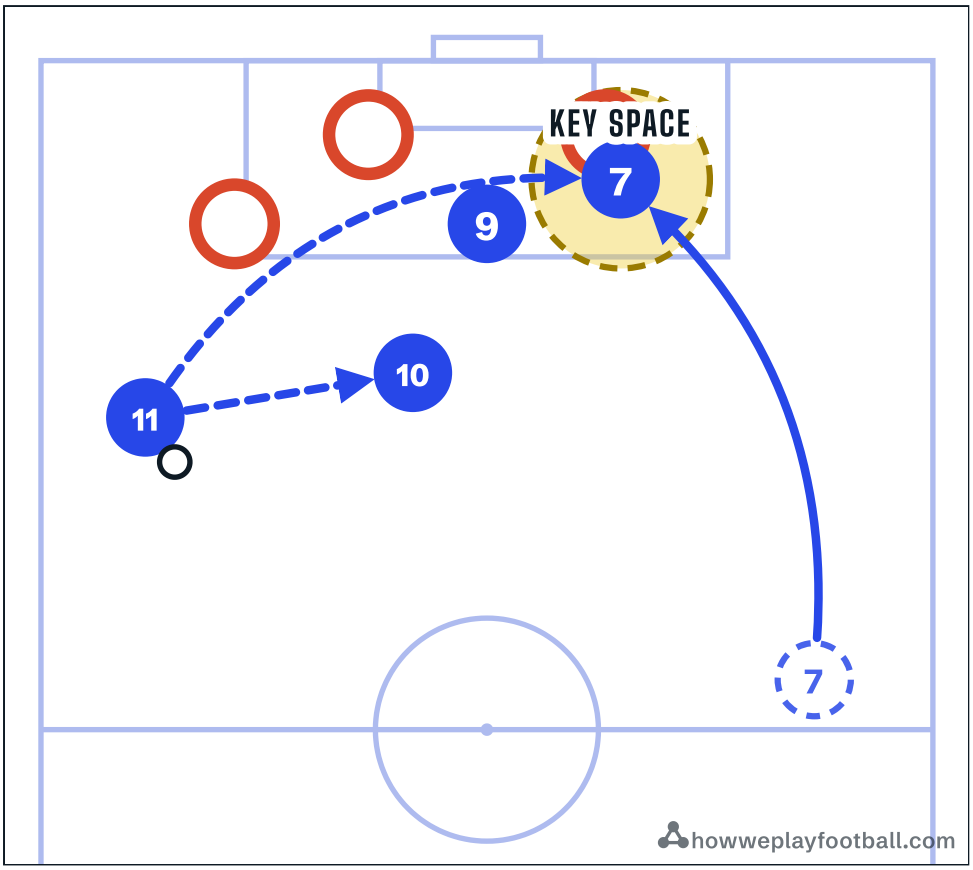


7 has the ball. 9 keeps their defenders busy. 10 supports. 11 gets in at the far post.

THE CUE

BALL ON YOUR SIDE: GIVE US WIDTH. BALL ON THE OTHER SIDE: ATTACK THE GOAL.

B ATTACK DOWN THE LEFT



11 has the ball. 7 gets in at the far post. Not one striker: three players who can score.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A 7 has the ball. 9 keeps their defenders busy. 10 supports. 11 gets in at the far post.

B Down the left it mirrors: 11 has the ball and 7 gets in at the far post.

READING THE DIAGRAMS

Us · Them · Ball · Started here · Run · Pass · Blocked · Key space · Gap

04 SHOW THEM WIDE, THEN GO

We don't need to chase the ball everywhere.

Protect the middle, guide them to the touchline, then press together.

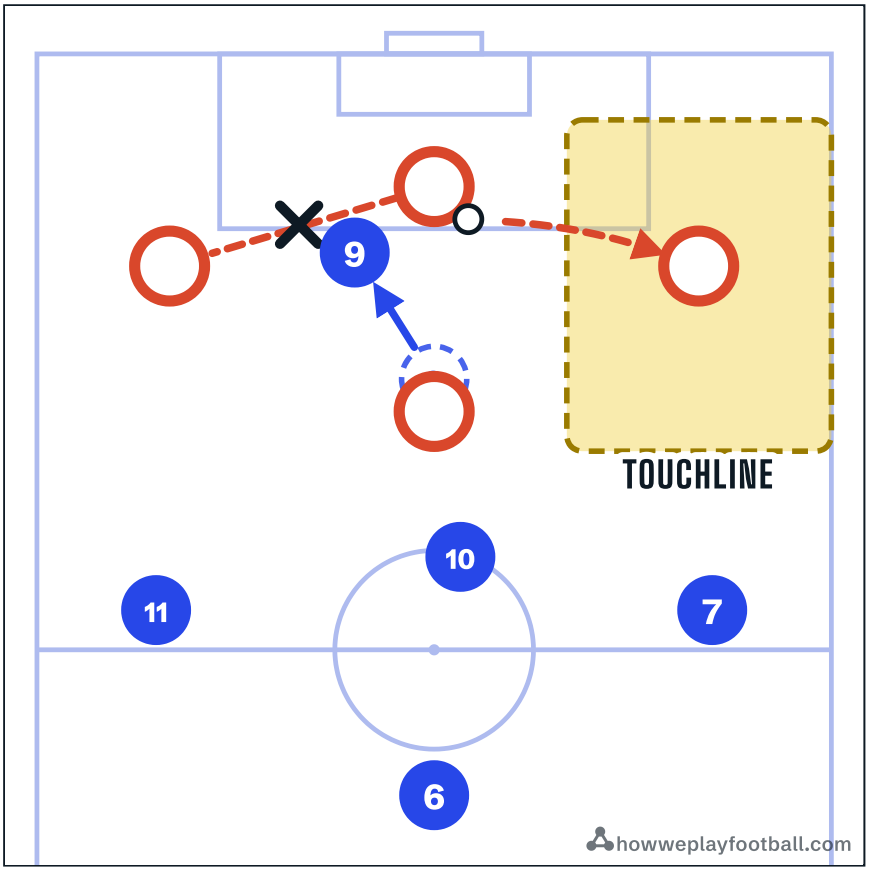
Go means the nearest players press together. It doesn't mean everyone charges at the ball.

Two steps: read 1, then 2.

WHO IT INVOLVES

6 The screen	p. 17
7 · 11 Wide players	p. 18
10 Number 10	p. 19
9 Striker	p. 20

1 SHOW THEM WIDE

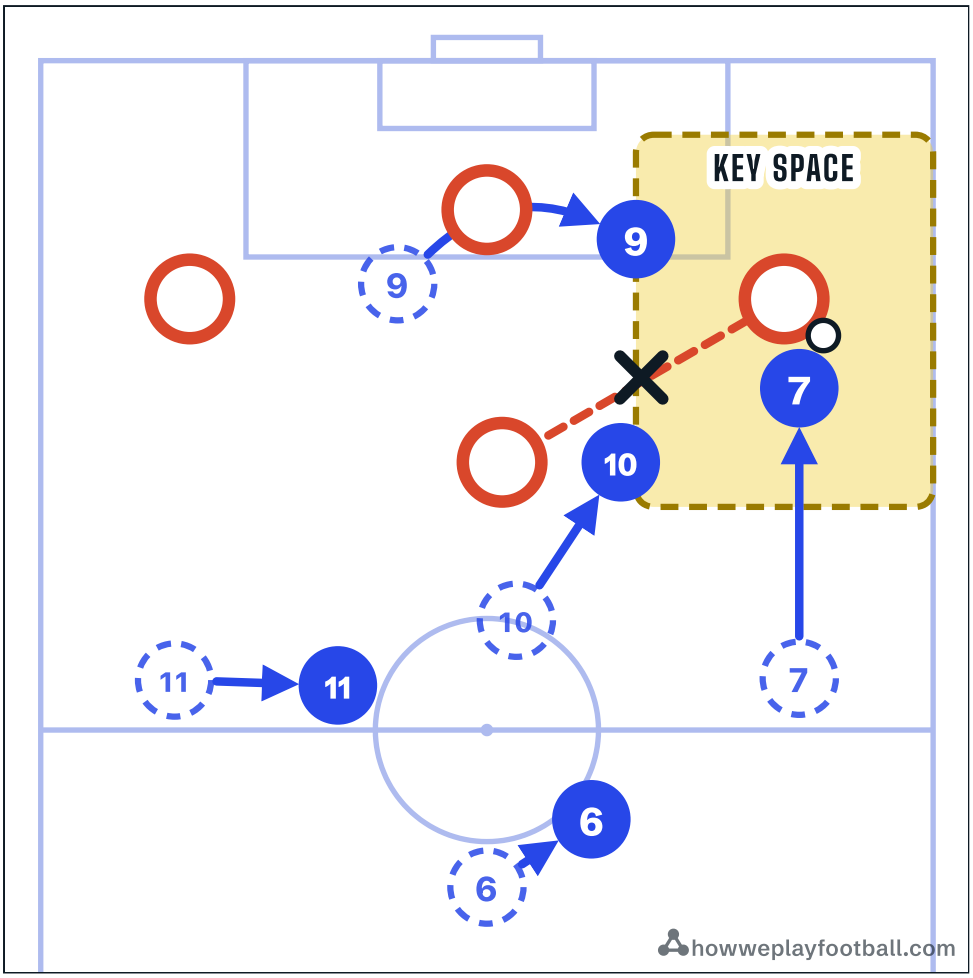


9 curves the run. The pass across or through the middle gets hard. The pass wide looks easy.

THE CUE

THE TOUCHLINE HELPS US DEFEND.

2 GO!



7 presses. 10 blocks the pass inside. 9 blocks the pass back. 6 protects behind. Everyone shifts across.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

1. Show them wide: 9 curves the run. The pass across or through the middle gets hard; the pass wide looks easy.
2. Go: 7 presses, 10 blocks the pass inside, 9 blocks the pass back, 6 protects behind. Everyone shifts across.

READING THE DIAGRAMS

Us · Them · Ball · Started here · Run · Pass · Blocked · Key space · Gap

GK GOALKEEPER

Start us playing

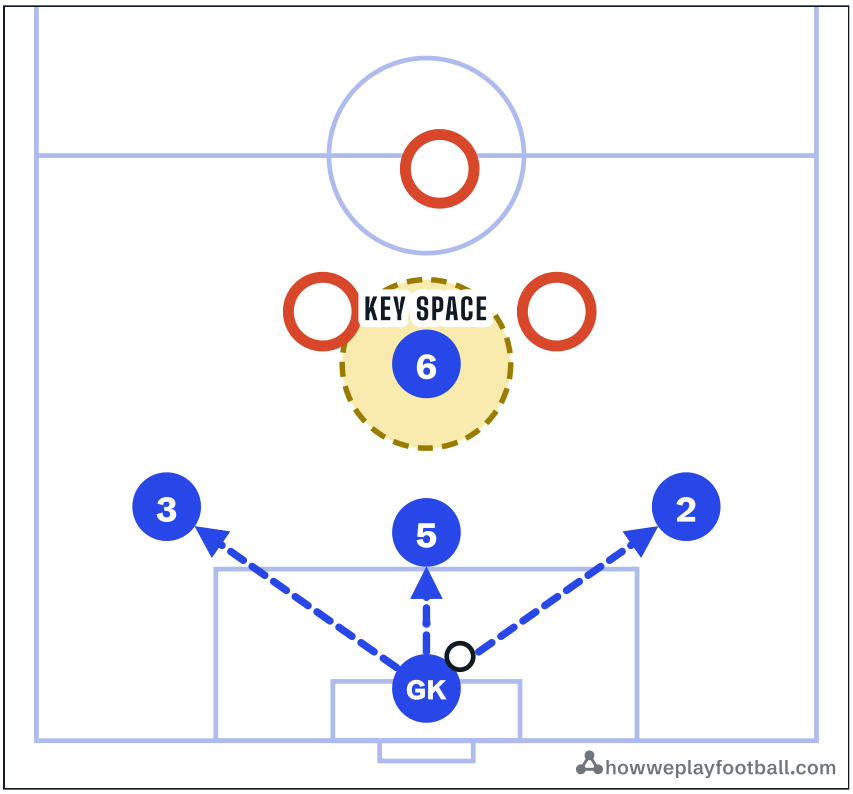
YOUR JOBS

- With the ball: short to 3, 5 or 2. The 6 is available in the middle, just ahead.
- Without it: talk. Left. Right. Man on. Turn. Drop.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

Middle first p. 6

A WITH THE BALL



Short to 3, 5 or 2. 6 is available in the middle, just ahead.

THE CUE

LOOK SHORT FIRST. IF IT ISN'T ON, DON'T FORCE IT.

5 CENTRE-BACK

Keep us secure

YOUR JOBS

- Protect the middle.
- Don't get dragged out unless somebody covers you.
- If nobody presses you, carry the ball forward.

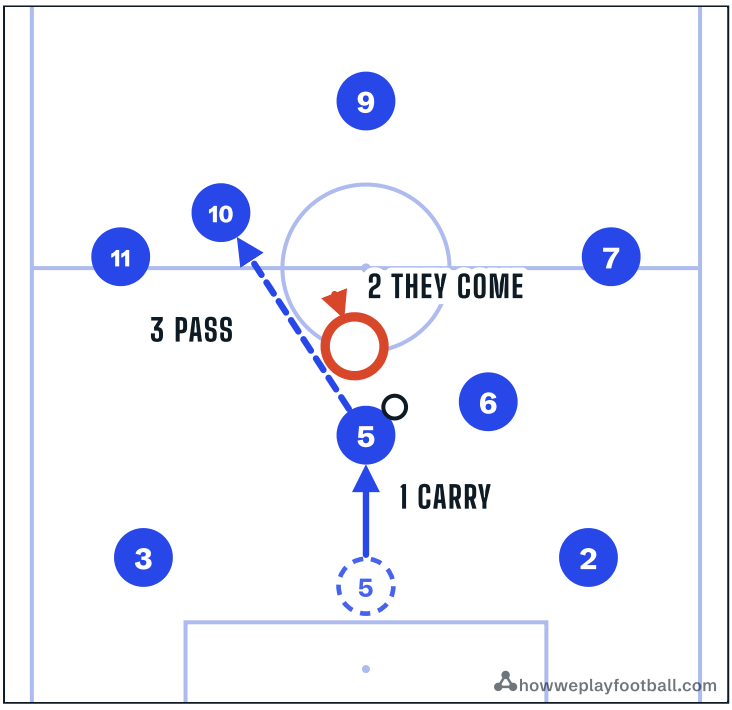
STEP BY STEP

1. Space ahead? Carry it forward.
2. Sooner or later an opponent has to come to you.
3. Now a teammate is free. Pass.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

Middle first	p. 6
One goes, one stays	p. 8

A CARRY, THEN PASS



1 Carry: space ahead, so 5 carries it forward. 2 They come: an opponent has to come to 5. 3 Pass: now a teammate is free.

THE CUE

CAN I STEP IN?

2 · 3 OUTSIDE DEFENDERS

Defend first. Support second.

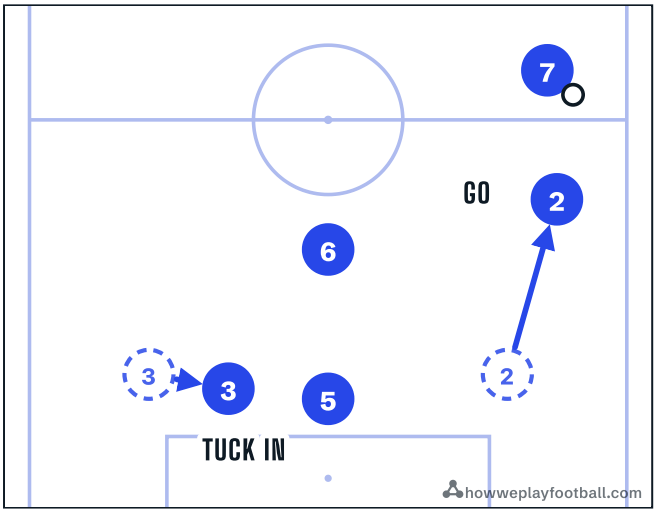
YOUR JOBS

- Your jobs, in order: defend, help us build, join the attack.
- Ball right: 2 can go forward. 3 tucks in, almost another centre-back.
- Ball left: 3 can go forward. 2 tucks in, almost another centre-back.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

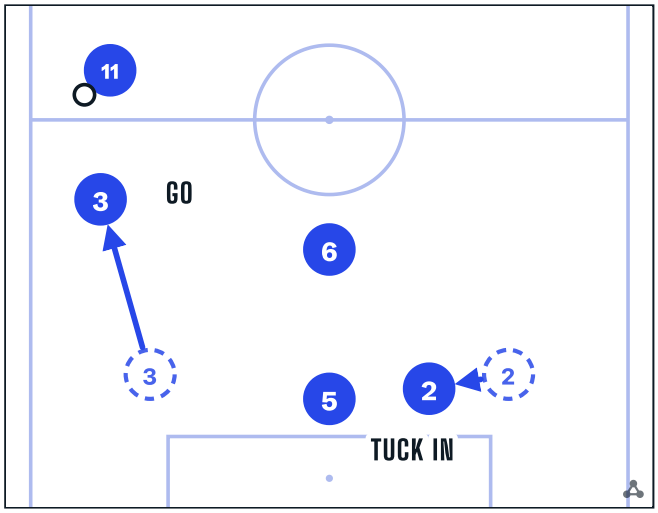
One goes, one stays p. 8

A BALL RIGHT



2 can go forward. 3 tucks in, almost another centre-back.

B BALL LEFT



3 can go forward. 2 tucks in, almost another centre-back.

THE CUE

ONE GOES. ONE STAYS.

6 THE SCREEN

Protect. Connect.

YOUR JOBS

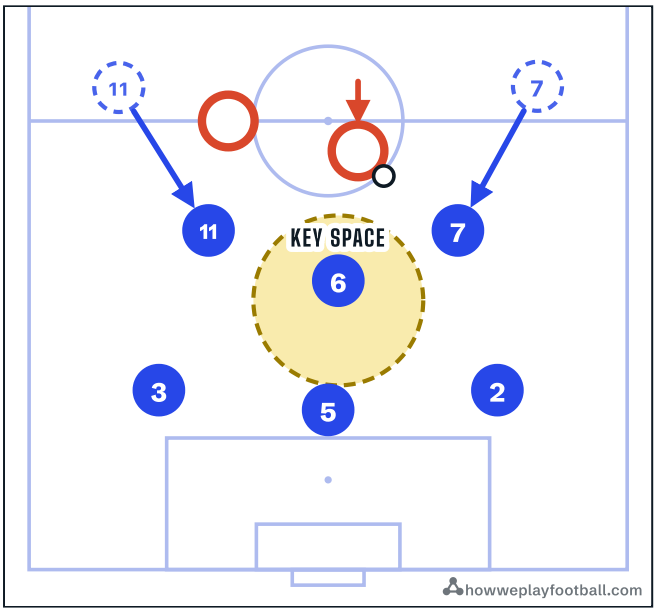
- Stay underneath the ball. Stay central.
- Show for possession. Protect us when we lose it.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

Middle first p. 6

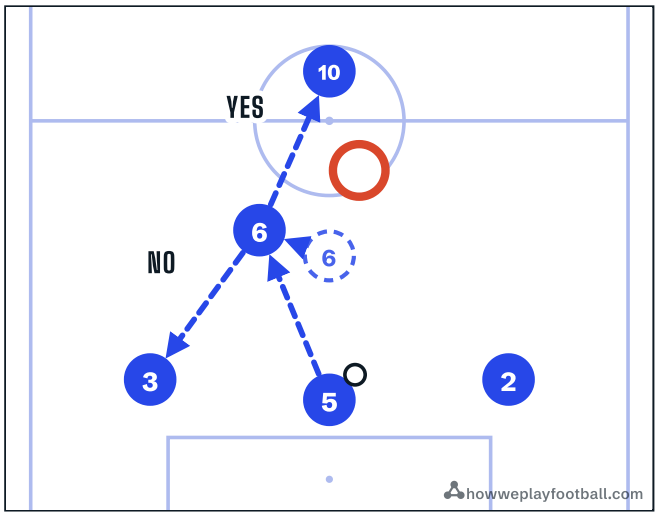
Show them wide, then go p. 12

A THEY BREAK AT US



Get between the attacker and 5. Slow them down, teammates recover, we defend together.

B WE WIN IT BACK



Move to find an angle, then ask: can I turn? Yes: look forward. No: play safely and move again.

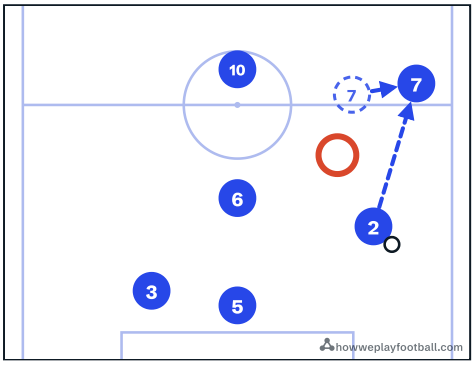
THE CUE

YOU DON'T HAVE TO WIN EVERY TACKLE. SOMETIMES STOPPING THEM GOING FORWARD IS ENOUGH.

7 · 11 WIDE PLAYERS

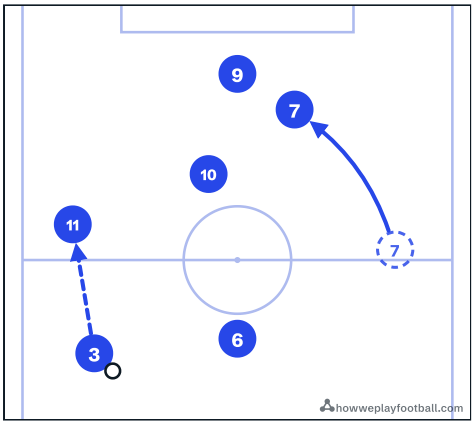
Wide when it's ours. Narrow when it isn't.

YOUR JOBS



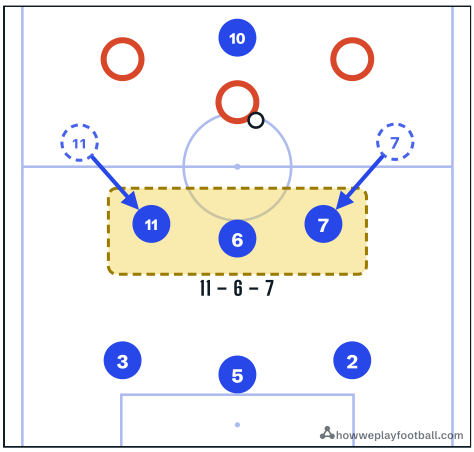
A BALL ON YOUR SIDE

Ball on your side: move wide. Give the player on the ball an easy pass.



B BALL ON THE OTHER SIDE

Ball on the other side: move inside. Attack the goal.



C THEY HAVE THE BALL

They have the ball: recover towards the centre first. Help protect the middle, in a line with the 6.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

Far side in	p. 10
Show them wide, then go	p. 12

THE CUE

WHERE'S THE BALL? THAT TELLS YOU WHERE TO GO.

10 NUMBER 10

Find the space

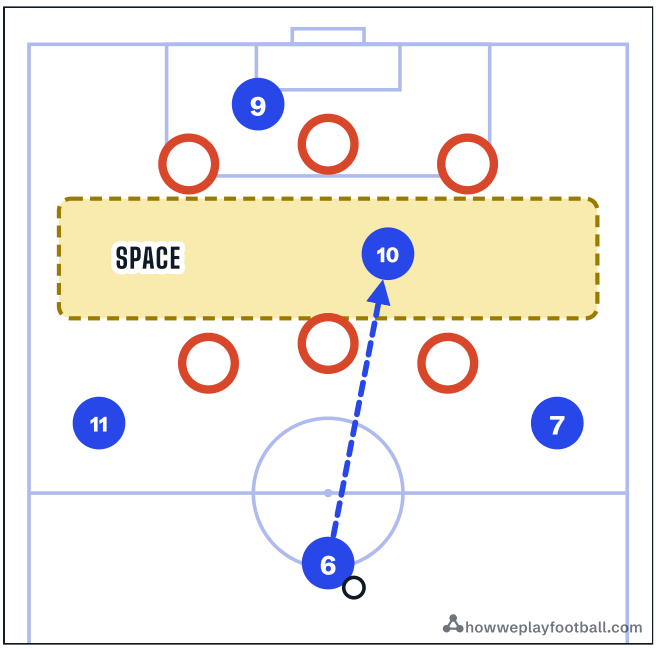
YOUR JOBS

- Find pockets of space.
- Get close enough to support 9.
- Look forward when you receive.
- Help us press when we lose it.
- You're not just a dribbler. You connect midfield and attack.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

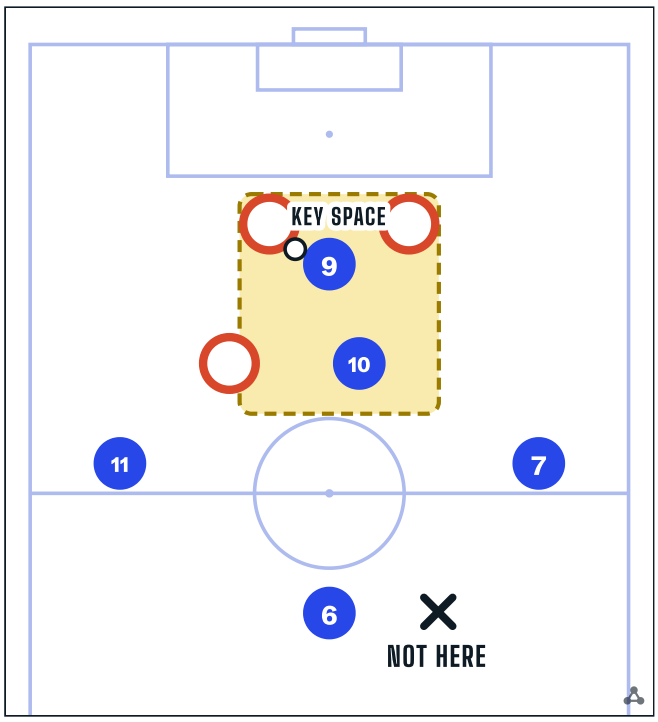
Show them wide, then go p. 12

A WITH THE BALL



Find pockets of space between their lines. Get close enough to support 9.

B WHEN WE DEFEND



Stay close to 9 so you can press together. Don't drop all the way back next to 6.

THE CUE

CAN I RECEIVE FACING THEIR GOAL?

9 STRIKER

Give us somewhere to play

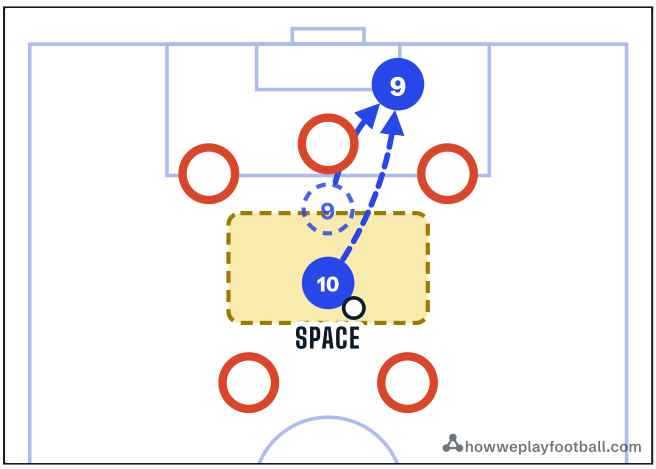
YOUR JOBS

- Stretch the defence.
- Give us a forward pass.
- Protect the ball when needed.
- Start our press.
- Know when to come short and when to run behind.

LINKED PRINCIPLES

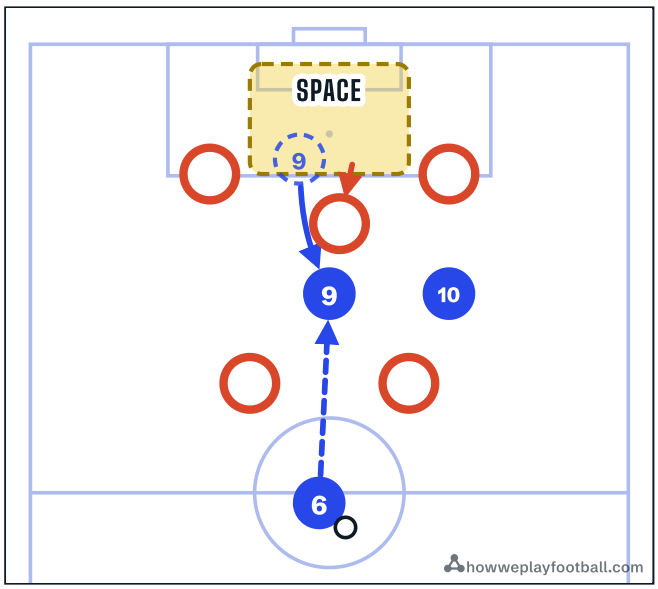
Show them wide, then go	p. 12
Far side in	p. 10

A RUN BEHIND



9 threatens the space behind. Their defenders drop, and space opens for 10.

B COME SHORT



9 checks towards the ball. A defender follows, and space opens behind.

THE CUE

BOTH MOVES MAKE SPACE FOR TEAMMATES.

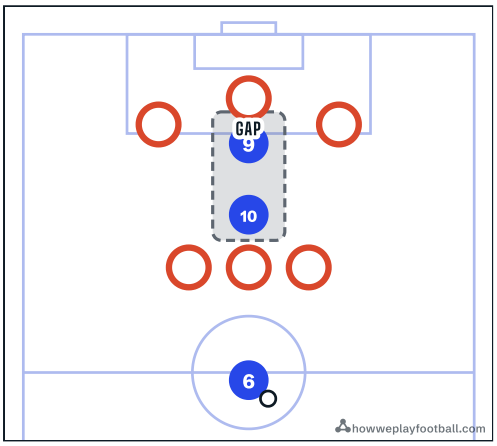
PLAYING TOGETHER

PLAYING TOGETHER: 9 AND 10

Don't stand in a line

A TOO EASY

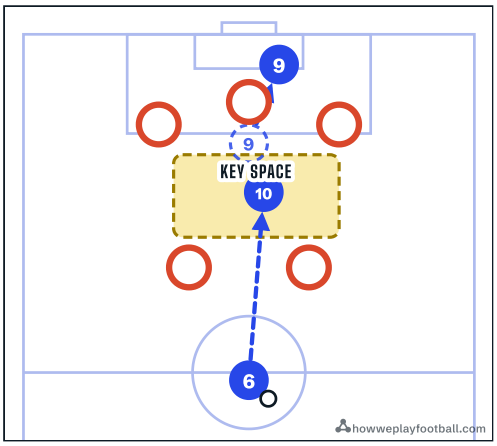
✕ WRONG



Too easy: 9 and 10 in the same line are easy to mark, and the pass to either is blocked.

B 9 RUNS, 10 RECEIVES

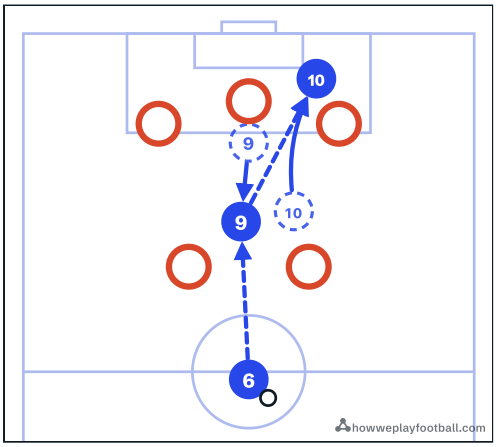
✓ RIGHT



9 runs, 10 receives: 9 stretches, 10 finds space.

C 9 COMES, 10 GOES

✓ RIGHT



9 comes, 10 goes: one comes, one goes.

THE CUE

MOVE FOR EACH OTHER.

COACHING REMINDERS

Every cue from this guide on one page. Take it to training and matches.

THE FORMATION IS OUR STARTING POSITION. IT ISN'T WHERE WE HAVE TO STAND.

THE FOUR PRINCIPLES

01 MIDDLE FIRST p. 6

IF YOU'RE NOT SURE WHETHER TO GO, STAY CENTRAL.

02 ONE GOES, ONE STAYS p. 8

IF THE OTHER DEFENDER GOES, YOU STAY.

03 FAR SIDE IN p. 10

BALL ON YOUR SIDE: GIVE US WIDTH. BALL ON THE OTHER SIDE: ATTACK THE GOAL.

04 SHOW THEM WIDE, THEN GO p. 12

THE TOUCHLINE HELPS US DEFEND.

A JOB FOR EVERY PLAYER

GK	Goalkeeper	Look short first. If it isn't on, don't force it.	p. 14
5	Centre-back	Can I step in?	p. 15
2 · 3	Outside defenders	One goes. One stays.	p. 16
6	The screen	You don't have to win every tackle. Sometimes stopping them going forward is enough.	p. 17
7 · 11	Wide players	Where's the ball? That tells you where to go.	p. 18
10	Number 10	Can I receive facing their goal?	p. 19
9	Striker	Both moves make space for teammates.	p. 20
9 + 10	Playing together	Move for each other.	p. 21

WHEN WE HAVE THE BALL

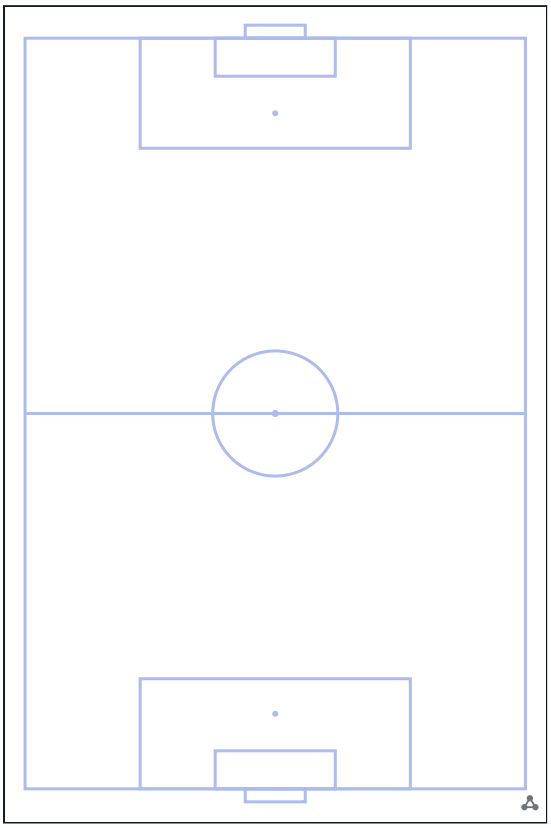
Far side in p. 10
9 and 10 together p. 21

WHEN THEY HAVE THE BALL

Middle first p. 6
Show them wide, then go p. 12

NOTES

DRAW YOUR OWN



KEEP GOING ONLINE

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Free formation guides for 7v7 and 9v9 football, with 5v5 in development.

SCAN FOR THE ONLINE GUIDE

THE 3-1-3-1 ONLINE

The same guide with animated diagrams and a page for every position.

howweplayfootball.com/formations/9v9/3-1-3-1

WATCH THE 3-1-3-1 EXPLAINED

Our animated explainer of the starting shape and the four principles, on YouTube.

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HOW WE PLAY FOOTBALL

Helping your team take the next step.

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